

The Niche Selection Worksheet

Find Your Best Niche in 15 Minutes — A Scoring Framework

Picking a niche is the highest-leverage decision you'll make as a freelancer. The wrong niche means constant price pressure, low budgets, and fighting for scraps. The right niche means clients who pay well, refer you often, and let you build repeatable systems. This worksheet removes the guesswork.

Time required: 15 minutes with a pen and honest self-assessment. Do not overthink each score — your gut reaction is usually right. You can always re-score later with real data.

STEP 1: LIST YOUR TOP 5 SKILLS

What can you actually deliver? Be specific. "Marketing" is too vague. "Email automation with n8n" is a skill. Write down 5 skills you could sell today.

#	Your Skill
1	
2	
3	
4	
5	

Example skills (Tarun's actual list):

1. AI/Workflow Automation (n8n, Make, Zapier)
2. CRM Setup & Optimization (ClickUp, HubSpot, GoHighLevel)
3. Email Marketing Automation
4. Content Repurposing Systems
5. Lead Generation & Data Scraping

STEP 2: LIST 5 INDUSTRIES YOU'VE TOUCHED

Where do you have experience, connections, or understanding? Even one project or a personal interest counts.

#	Your Industry
1	
2	
3	
4	
5	

Example industries (Tarun's actual list):

1. Staffing & Recruitment
2. E-commerce / DTC Brands
3. Healthcare / Medical Practices
4. Coaching & Online Education
5. Construction / Industrial

STEP 3: SCORE EACH COMBINATION

Now cross your skills with your industries and score each combination on 5 criteria. Each criterion is scored 1-5.

Scoring Criteria Explained

Criterion	What to Assess	How to Score
Demand (1-5)	How many people are actively looking to buy this?	Search Upwork for "[skill] [industry]." 1 = under 10 jobs/month. 5 = 50+ jobs/month.
Budget (1-5)	How much do clients in this niche typically pay?	Look at posted budgets. 1 = under \$500. 3 = \$1K-\$5K. 5 = \$5K+.
Competition (1-5, inverted)	How crowded is this space?	Count competing freelancers. 1 = extremely crowded. 5 = very few competitors.
Experience (1-5)	How much do you already know about this combo?	1 = never done it. 3 = done it once. 5 = multiple projects with case studies.
Interest (1-5)		

How much do you
actually enjoy this work?

1 = dread it. 3 = neutral. 5 = would do it
for free (but don't).

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE: TARUN'S SCORES

Here is how the scoring looked for Tarun's top 5 combinations. The winner is highlighted.

Skill x Industry	Demand	Budget	Competition	Experience	Interest	Total
AI Automation x Staffing	5	4	3	5	5	22
AI Automation x Healthcare	4	5	3	4	4	20
CRM Setup x E-commerce	4	3	2	3	3	15
Lead Gen x Construction	3	4	4	4	3	18
Email Automation x Coaching	4	3	2	3	4	16
Content Systems x E-commerce	3	3	2	3	4	15

Winner: AI Automation x Staffing scored 22/25. Here's why it won:

- **Demand (5):** Staffing firms are desperate to automate hiring — 50+ Upwork jobs posted monthly for recruitment automation.
- **Budget (4):** Average project \$3K-\$15K. Tarun's biggest was \$14,840. Staffing firms have revenue to invest.
- **Competition (3):** Moderate. Many "automation" freelancers, but few specialize in staffing-specific workflows.
- **Experience (5):** 15 staffing firms served. Hiring cut from 6 weeks to 1 week. Qualified rate from 40% to 78%. Proven results.

Check 2: The Pain Test (5 minutes)

Can you answer "yes" to all 3?

- Does this industry have a painful, repetitive process that eats time?
- Is the cost of NOT solving this problem measurable in dollars or hours?
- Are businesses currently paying employees to do this manually?

Tarun's answer for Staffing: Yes to all 3. Recruiters were spending 6 weeks per hire, losing candidates to faster competitors, and paying 3+ people to do what one workflow can do.

Check 3: The Proof Test (5 minutes)

Do you have (or can you quickly create) at least ONE piece of proof?

- A case study with real numbers
- A before/after screenshot
- A testimonial from a past client
- A demo project you built for yourself

Tarun's proof: 15 staffing firms served, hiring time cut from 6 weeks to 1 week, qualified rate from 40% to 78%, 93-98% email open rates. Multiple case studies.

Your niche is not permanent. It is a starting point. Pick the highest-scoring option, dominate it for 6 months, build case studies, then expand. Tarun started with staffing automation and expanded into healthcare (30% ad spend reduction, 32-40% conversion increase) and industrial (14K leads via hidden API reverse engineering). The first niche funds the second.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

1. **Claim your niche in your bio:** "I help [industry] companies [outcome] using [skill]."
2. **Update your Upwork title:** "[Skill] Specialist for [Industry]"
3. **Create 3 pieces of content** speaking directly to that niche's pain points
4. **Build one case study** (even a demo project counts) showing the transformation
5. **Send 10 cold outreach messages** to companies in your niche this week